
PRODUCTBEACON

The State of Digital Intelligence 2026

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Front 5 – Open-Source Intelligence (OSINT / WEBINT)

An independent ProductBeacon market briefing on the government & national-security intelligence software market – lawful interception, OSINT/WEBINT, decision intelligence. Front 5 of six.

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Glossary.

- **OSINT (Open-Source Intelligence)** – intelligence produced from publicly accessible, openly-available sources (web, social, public records, breach corpora, geospatial, technical data), collected and exploited without privileged network access, a warrant, or field hardware.¹
- **WEBINT (Web Intelligence)** – the web-resident subset of OSINT: data collected from the internet (surface, deep, and dark web) and processed toward an investigative objective; in vendor usage, often the umbrella term for an integrated web-collection-plus-exploitation platform.²
- **SOCMINT (Social Media Intelligence)** – a subset of OSINT restricted to social-platform data: the collection and analysis of posts, networks, and metadata (timestamps, geolocation) to reveal information about individuals, groups, or trends.³

5.1 The Playing Ground

Open-source intelligence is the discipline of gathering and exploiting information that is already in the open. The sources are the web, social platforms, public records, breach corpora, satellite imagery, and the technical exhaust of the internet itself. The work is turning that raw material into something an analyst can act on. One vendor glossary in this exact market defines OSINT as “the process of gathering, analyzing, and utilizing information from publicly accessible sources.” It enumerates those sources as “social media platforms, websites and blogs, public government data, satellite imagery, public databases, academic publications and gray literature, technical data (WHOIS, DNS, Certificate Transparency), news and media outlets, public forums and online communities, leaked data, geospatial data, publicly available corporate documents, [and the] dark web.”⁴ The buyer is a national-intelligence or national-security agency, a law-enforcement investigations unit, a defense or military-intelligence cell, a corporate-security or threat-intelligence function, or a financial-crime and due-diligence team.

The defining property of this front — the line that keeps the chapter coherent — is the *source being open and web-resident*. Access is unprivileged: a vendor or its customer can reach the source without a court order, a carrier tap, or a deployed device. That single property separates OSINT from every other front in this report, and it is worth stating the boundary precisely, because “open-source intelligence” is the front most prone to category sprawl. The word “open” gets stretched to cover anything that touches the internet, and the result is double-counting.

What this front IS. Collection and exploitation of openly-available, web-resident, social, and dark-web data, where the access is unprivileged. The core product is the open-source *collection-and-exploitation engine*: the scrapers, the dark-web crawlers, the social harvesters, the multilingual entity extraction over web text. The collector is graded here, in Open-Source Intelligence.

What this front is NOT. Three boundaries matter.

First, it is *not* intercepted content. Three other fronts depend on *privileged* access to a communications channel: the mass network collection of the National Agencies front, the warrant-scoped lawful interception of the Law Enforcement Monitoring Centers front, and the field radio-frequency collection of the Tactical Intelligence front. OSINT touches only what is openly broadcast or published. The bright line is the *privilege of access, not the subject matter*. A vendor can detect a threat actor’s chatter on a public Telegram channel and stay firmly inside Open-Source Intelligence; intercepting that same actor’s private call requires the machinery of the intercept fronts. Same target, different front, because the access right differs.

Second, it is *not* the fusion layer that *ingests* OSINT. An OSINT *collector* belongs to Open-Source Intelligence; a *fusion platform that ingests OSINT* belongs to the Fusion / Decision Intelligence front, with an Open-Source Intelligence reference. The test that keeps these apart is whether the *collection* or the *analytics-over-supplied-data* is the primary product. A vendor whose primary value is the open-source collection engine is graded here. A vendor whose primary value is multi-source analytics on top of feeds the customer supplies — link analysis, case management, cross-source correlation — is graded in the fusion front and merely referenced here. This is the single most important grading discipline for this front. Every serious OSINT vendor also markets analytics, so the only question that resolves the ambiguity is which half of the product the buyer is actually paying for.

Third, it is *not* generic cyber threat-intelligence that is not open-source-derived. Malware telemetry, honeypot data, proprietary sensor networks, and vendor-internal sinkhole data are threat intelligence but not OSINT — they are *proprietary* collection. Where a vendor blends OSINT with proprietary feeds, only the open-source-derived portion is the Open-Source Intelligence capability; the rest is adjacent. The heavy overlap between “OSINT platform” and “cyber threat-intelligence platform” is exactly why this front’s vendor universe overflows. The front’s problem is not finding enough contenders to grade. It is cutting the field down to the ones whose open-source collection is genuinely the product.

Three buyer misconceptions

“OSINT is free — it’s all on Google.” The public-source *raw material* is free; the differentiated product is everything that sits on top of it. Collection at scale, dark-web access, multilingual coverage, de-duplication and entity-resolution, and a provenance trail are what a buyer actually pays for. Babel Street, for example, markets searching “across thousands of sources... in over 200 languages with citations and data provenance.”⁵ The citations and the provenance are the product, not the raw posts. There is a real

free floor here: community-edition tools and open-source toolkits, and increasingly general-purpose large language models running ad-hoc collection.⁶ But that floor only compresses the *low end* of basic open-web collection. It pushes commercial vendors up-stack, toward the capabilities the free tools cannot match.

“OSINT and SOCMINT are the same thing.” Social-media intelligence is a *subset* of OSINT, restricted to social platforms. OSINT spans the entire open web, public records, technical data, breach corpora, and geospatial sources.^{2 3} A vendor strong in social collection is not automatically strong in dark-web or breach-data collection; they are different disciplines with different access problems.

“If it’s public, collecting it is legal.” Public *visibility* does not equal *lawful collection*. Platform terms-of-service, anti-circumvention rules, and data-protection law all constrain *how* public data may be gathered – and the constraint has teeth, as the scraping litigation below shows.

The data and collection stack

The front has two strata: a collection-and-source layer, and an exploitation-and-analytics layer that turns raw open data into structured intelligence. Almost all the differentiation lives in *which sources a vendor can reach* and *how well it exploits them*.

On the collection side, the source classes line up roughly by how hard they are to reach.

The **surface web** – indexed news, blogs, corporate sites, forums, public-records portals – is the cheapest and most contested layer. Everyone collects it, and this is where scraping legality bites. Technical data (WHOIS, DNS, Certificate Transparency) sits here too, as a distinct “technical OSINT” discipline.

The **deep web** – content behind forms, logins, paywalls, or simply not indexed – is reachable without special privilege, but it requires per-source connectors and query automation. Deep-web *breadth* – the number of gated-but-public databases a vendor has built connectors for – is a quiet moat that is hard to verify from outside. I’d hypothesize that vendors’ “thousands of sources” claims gesture at this connector inventory, though, as the collection-breadth axis below notes, the figure is not independently verifiable.

The **dark web** – Tor and I2P forums, ransomware leak sites, illicit marketplaces, closed channels – is a specialist discipline requiring persona management, access maintenance, and operational tradecraft. Vendors anchor here explicitly, with Cybersixgill describing automated collection “from dark web forums, marketplaces, and social media platforms,”⁷ Flashpoint marketing intelligence across “Dark Web, Malware, Vulnerability, OSINT, Financial, Domain, Identity” classes,⁸ and Fivecast publishing a dedicated dark-web collection methodology.⁹

The **social layer** (SOCMINT) – posts, networks, metadata, sentiment – is the most legally exposed modality, for reasons the scraping case below makes plain.

Breach and leaked data – credential dumps and leaked databases circulating in cybercrime channels – is a recognized OSINT source class⁴ used for identity-resolution and exposure monitoring. It carries the heaviest data-protection and provenance risk of any source here.

Multilingual content — coverage of non-Latin scripts and low-resource languages — is a hard collection-and-exploitation problem that vendors market as a primary discriminator. Babel Street positions on processing “any publicly available input in hundreds of languages.”⁵ For a national-security buyer whose targets operate in Arabic, Farsi, Russian, Mandarin, and regional dialects, language coverage is not a feature line. It is a gating capability.

On the exploitation side, the analytics that stays *inside* an Open-Source Intelligence product — as distinct from a standalone fusion platform — runs to a handful of functions. They are collection orchestration and de-duplication, multilingual entity extraction and resolution, identity-graph construction across selectors, anomaly and network analysis over social data, and alerting on standing queries. The 2026 inflection adds large-language-model-assisted summarization and natural-language investigation. The grading test holds: this analytics stays inside Open-Source Intelligence when it operates over the vendor’s own open-source collection, and tips into the fusion front only when it is sold standalone over customer-supplied feeds.

The six axes buyers discriminate on

Six dimensions separate the serious vendors from the rest, and each maps to a real, publicly observable cost-and-capability structure.

1. **Language and translation coverage.** The breadth of languages a vendor can *collect, translate, and entity-resolve* — not merely keyword-match. The public proxy is the vendor’s own stated language count tied to provenance (Babel Street’s “over 200 languages”⁵). This is the hardest-to-fake axis: keyword translation is cheap, but cross-script entity-resolution at investigative grade is not. I read a vendor’s willingness to publish a specific language count tied to provenance as a stronger signal than a generic “multilingual” claim.
2. **Dark and deep-web depth.** Reach into Tor and I2P forums, ransomware leak sites, and gated-but-public databases — plus the tradecraft to maintain access. The public proxy is a *published* collection methodology and explicit source-class enumeration^{8 9} versus generic “we monitor the dark web” marketing. This is where the cyber-threat-intel cohort out-differentiates the social-first WEBINT cohort.
3. **Collection breadth.** The raw count and diversity of connected sources across surface, deep, social, dark, breach, and records. The public proxy is the “thousands of sources” claim — directionally informative but *not independently verifiable*, so they read as positioning claims, not facts, unless tied to a published source inventory.
4. **LLM-native versus bolt-on AI — as positioning, not verified architecture.** An outside party cannot verify a vendor’s true internal architecture. So this axis must be read as *how a vendor markets itself*, with a falsifiable test on public proxies. The 2026 market is visibly bifurcating between vendors retrofitting generative AI onto an existing collection stack and vendors positioning AI as the native interface. Babel Street markets “agentic AI” explicitly: “Insights Investigator is agentic AI that gives analysts a single natural language interface to run threat investigations, monitor emerging risks, and surface connections” and “plans and executes multi-step workflows.”¹⁰ I read “agentic AI” and “natural language interface” as the current category-defining positioning move in this front — not yet a verified architectural moat. The test runs through the second half of 2026. If the agentic-OSINT

entrants publish named government reference wins or independent (not vendor-asserted) time-to-insight benchmarks, the LLM-native claim graduates from positioning to a defensible differentiator. If they do not, it stays a watchlist item rather than a claim the analysis can lean on.

5. **Identity-graph and correlation depth.** How deeply a vendor resolves selectors — an email, a phone, a handle, an image — into unified entities, and maps relationships across sources. This is the difference between “here are forty hits for this handle” and “here is the resolved person, their aliases, their network, with provenance on each edge.” The public proxy is published case studies and the presence of cross-source correlation in product descriptions, versus single-source search.
6. **Data provenance and defensibility.** Whether collected intelligence carries an auditable chain — source, timestamp, citation — that survives legal and evidentiary scrutiny, and whether the *collection method itself* is defensible (terms-of-service-compliant, not fake-account scraping). The public proxy is explicit “citations and data provenance” positioning⁵ and, inversely, litigation exposure. I read provenance and defensibility as having flipped from a compliance checkbox to a *competitive* axis. A buyer that adopts a vendor whose collection method is legally contestable inherits that vendor’s litigation risk. So defensible collection is now a sales differentiator, not just a hygiene item.

The public barriers

Two structural barriers are most specific to this front, and one — scraping legality — has no analog anywhere else in this report.

Export controls on surveillance technology. Open-source tooling sold for surveillance use sits inside the dual-use export-control net. That net gates *who* a vendor may sell to across borders. The multilateral baseline is the 42-state Wassenaar Arrangement, which added commercial surveillance technologies to its dual-use control list beginning in 2013. The precise placement matters and is often mis-stated. In the implementing regimes, *intrusion-software* controls fall under **Category 4 (Computers)**, while *IP-network communications surveillance systems* fall under **Category 5 Part 1 (Telecommunications)** — not both under “Category 5,” as the shorthand sometimes has it.¹¹

The U.S. implementation came via a Bureau of Industry and Security interim final rule published on 2021-10-21. It controls two categories. The first is software “specially designed... for the generation, command and control, or delivery of ‘intrusion software’” under ECCN 4D004. The second is “IP network communications surveillance systems or equipment” under ECCN 5A001.j. Both are controlled for national-security and anti-terrorism reasons, and a new License Exception ACE (Authorized Cybersecurity Exports) carves out certain destinations.¹²

The European Union’s Dual-Use Regulation 2021/821 adds an Article 5 catch-all on cyber-surveillance items. It requires an export authorization where the items “are or may be intended for use in connection with internal repression and/or the commission of serious violations of human rights.” Covered technologies named in the guidance include “telecommunications interception systems, internet surveillance systems, intrusion software and forensic tools.”¹³ One honest qualifier: a public analysis from SIPRI finds that “use of the new catch-all control has been limited to date”¹³ — the control exists on paper, but enforcement practice is still maturing.

Pure open-source collection over public data sits at the lighter-touch end of this net relative to intrusion and implant tooling. But the export-control frame supplies the front's legitimacy boundary, and it is the natural place to seat the surveillance-vendor discussion. One discipline binds throughout. Any certification or clearance claim about a named vendor must cite the certifying body or the vendor's own public statement, never an analyst assertion — a wrong certification claim on a named company is a credibility *and* a defamation hit.

Platform terms-of-service and scraping legality. This barrier has no analog in the intercept fronts, because this front collects from *third-party platforms whose terms bind the collector*. The clearest public case is Meta v. Voyager Labs. Meta sued Voyager in January 2023 in the Northern District of California, alleging that Voyager “created 38,000 Facebook accounts” and used them “to scrape data from more than 600,000 social media users,” including “posts, likes, friend lists, photos, and comments.”¹⁴ In May 2024, U.S. District Judge Araceli Martinez-Olguin allowed the suit to proceed, rejecting Voyager's motion to dismiss and finding that Meta's allegations could support claims that Voyager violated Facebook's and Instagram's terms of service.¹⁵ The case ultimately settled, with Voyager agreeing “to refrain from scraping Facebook and Instagram and to permanently delete any data collected from Meta.”¹⁶

Voyager is in this report's never-graded set, so this is descriptive market structure only, not a pattern claim about the company. But the structure it reveals is real: a major platform pursued, and a court allowed to proceed, terms-based claims against an OSINT vendor for collecting *publicly visible* data through fake accounts, and the matter ended in a settlement that barred the collection. I read the case as the public market's clearest signal that *collection method* — not just *what data is public* — is now a structural constraint on this front, and that platform enforcement is a live competitive variable. The test runs through the second half of 2026. If additional platform-versus-vendor enforcement actions surface in the public record as named filings or settlements, the “defensible collection” axis hardens into a table-stakes procurement question. If enforcement stays a one-off, it remains an elevated-risk axis rather than a gate.

Behind the single case sits a genuinely unsettled legal backdrop across jurisdictions — U.S. terms-breach theories, EU lawful-basis and purpose-limitation constraints on reusing personal data, platform anti-circumvention rules. The *absence* of a settled rule is itself the barrier: each vendor must make a defensibility bet, and that bet is now visible in both its positioning and its litigation exposure.

Clearance and accreditation. For U.S.-federal and allied national-security buyers, the software-side gates that recur across this report apply here too: facility and personnel security clearances, and cloud accreditation (FedRAMP authorization, DoD Impact Levels) for hosted delivery. I did not extract a verbatim accreditation-requirement line from a live OSINT-specific U.S. solicitation in this pass. So the specific magnitude and timeline of the gate is an inference from the regime's general applicability rather than a quoted fact — a thin spot worth naming as one. The war-chest analysis later in this chapter is better placed to answer it, through the pattern of specialists acquiring cleared U.S. delivery organizations.

One freshness correction for the contenders that follow. As of a 2026-06-14 web check, Cobwebs Technologies operates under PenLink, both held by the private-equity firm Spire Capital, with the Cobwebs-to-Spire transaction reported at roughly USD 200 million. PenLink is integrating Cobwebs' web-intelligence capability into its digital-investigation platform for “law enforcement, public safety, and

national security customers.”¹⁷ Babel Street does *not* own PenLink or Cobwebs — those sit under Spire Capital, and Babel Street is a separate vendor.¹⁷ The contenders and war-chest sections re-verify any 2026 ownership before grading.

5.2 The Terrain

Market size: three estimates, side by side, never averaged

There is no single number for the size of the OSINT market, and the honest way to present the sizing is to put the public estimates next to each other and let the spread speak. Three named research publishers size the broad OSINT market, and their definitions diverge widely enough that the disagreement is the finding, not a measurement error to be smoothed away.

Publisher	Definition used	Figure (as stated)	CAGR / period
Mordor Intelligence	software platforms, data feeds, and managed services that gather, enrich, and analyze information in publicly available domains (excludes classified intel, standalone threat-hunting, hardware-only sensors)	USD 18.20B (2025) → USD 21.06B (2026) → USD 43.49B (2031) ¹⁸	15.62% (2026–2031)
The Business Research Company	OSINT revenues from “human intelligence and dark web analysis”; factory-gate values	USD 18.07B (2025) → USD 22.95B (2026) → USD 60.02B (2030) ¹⁹	27.2% (to 2030)
GlobalData / Global Market Insights	OSINT “gathered from publicly available sources” across government and commercial sectors	USD 12.7B (2025) → USD 15.9B (2026) → USD 133.6B (2035) ²⁰	26.7% (2026–2035)

The three publishers bracket the 2025 OSINT market at roughly USD 12.7B–18.2B, and the 2026 market at roughly USD 15.9B–22.95B. The growth rates split into two camps: Mordor’s mid-teens against the two high-twenties figures. I read this as a genuinely unsettled category boundary rather than a counting error. Mordor’s definition explicitly *excludes* standalone threat-hunting and hardware sensors. That is why its base and growth rate sit below the wider-scoped figures that fold dark-web analysis and broader cyber-intelligence into “OSINT.” If a fourth named publisher with a disclosed methodology lands inside USD 13–19B for 2025, the bracket holds; a figure outside it would mean the definitional drift is wider than I have assumed.

It is worth marking the overlap boundary with an adjacent, separately-tracked market. Mordor sizes the broader *threat intelligence* market at USD 9.21B (2025) rising to USD 18.85B (2031) at a 12.7% CAGR, with the strategic-intelligence segment at a 33.60% revenue share.²¹ Grand View Research separately projects the threat-intelligence platforms market to USD 36.53B by 2030.²² I include these only to fix the

seam. Cyber-threat-intel and OSINT share vendors — Recorded Future, Flashpoint, Cybersixgill all appear in both — but are tracked as distinct markets, and double-counting across the two is the principal sizing hazard in this front.

The government slice: a labeled proxy, not a segment size

No clean public dollar figure isolates the government and national-security OSINT software slice. Given the opacity of government intelligence budgets, that is an expected, honest result, not a gap to be filled by invention. What *is* publicly stated is the government *share* of the OSINT market by named publishers, which I carry strictly as a proxy — a share-of-market, not a standalone segment size. Mordor puts government intelligence agencies at 38.40% of 2025 OSINT revenue, the single largest end-user segment, with military and defense as a further distinct category.¹⁸ Global Market Insights puts national security at 32% of 2025 market value, the dominant application segment, covering “counterterrorism, counter-intelligence, strategic warning and foreign capability assessment.”²⁰

Applying those published shares to the publishers' own market totals is bracketing arithmetic, and I label it as exactly that, not as a publisher figure. Mordor's 38.40% government share of its USD 18.20B total implies an order-of-magnitude proxy near USD 7B for the government-intelligence OSINT slice in 2025. GMI's 32% national-security share of its USD 12.7B total implies near USD 4B. The proxy range — roughly USD 4–7B for 2025 — is arithmetic on published *application-share* splits, not a methodology-disclosed segment sizing, and no publisher sells the latter. The harder currency for this front is not any market-derivative at all; it is the named, dated procurement evidence below.

Demand drivers

Three forcing functions carry the analytical weight that the market numbers cannot.

The open-data exhaust has outrun manual analysis. The publishers converge on a single root driver: the volume of openly-available data has grown faster than any analyst team can read it. Global Market Insights frames demand around the “rapid increase in publicly available online data” across “blogs, social media sites, news sites, web forums, internet of things (IoT) devices.”²⁰ Multilingual scale is a named buyer requirement rather than a feature. Babel Street states publicly that it analyzes content across “over 200 languages,” finding connections in multilingual data “from social media, the deep web, and public records.”²³ (Dataminr's own filing-grade description cites “trillions of daily computations across billions of public data inputs from over 100,000 unique public data sources.” It spans “global and regional social media platforms, blogs, web forums... the deep and dark web, cyber signals, and public IoT sensors” — a vivid statement of the source span. But it dates to a 2021-03-23 press release, so I carry it as a description of breadth, not as a current metric.²⁴) Dark and deep-web depth is a distinct vector the publishers single out, with The Business Research Company defining part of its OSINT market as “dark web analysis” revenue.¹⁹ Every expansion of the open-data exhaust — more platforms, more languages, more dark-web venues — widens the gap between what is publicly knowable and what a human can manually process. That gap is precisely what commercial platforms monetize.

Government buyers are institutionalizing OSINT as a named discipline. The U.S. intelligence community has publicly committed to OSINT as a standing mission rather than an ad-hoc capability. The CIA has publicly released an OSINT strategy that calls for building data-science and AI talent and

explicitly enlists large language models in its OSINT mission.²⁵ The buyer set the publishers name is broad and government-weighted — government intelligence agencies, military and defense, federal, state, and local law enforcement, plus financial-services and corporate-security threat-intel teams.^{18 20} Recorded Future's own public client claim — “more than 1,900 clients across 75 countries, including the governments of 45 countries” — is a public datapoint on the government density of the buyer base.²⁶

A commercial base sits below the government buyers. The same publishers that put government at 32–38% of revenue also show financial services, cybersecurity providers, and corporate-risk firms as material end-user segments.^{18 20} I read this as the structurally important feature of this front relative to the classified-collection fronts. OSINT has a large *commercial* recurring-revenue base — the part that needs no warrant and no clearance — which several specialists use as the platform from which they attack government tenders. If the named OSINT specialists' public disclosures show government revenue growing materially faster than commercial through 2027, the “commercial base funds the government push” read weakens.

The AI and LLM shift

The clearest 2025–2026 public signal in this front is that the incumbents are re-positioning around generative and agentic AI to compress the analyst workflow. The discipline here is the same one the differentiation axis above demands: this is framed strictly as what vendors *publicly claim*, because true architecture cannot be verified from outside — “positions itself as,” not “is.”

The capital is explicitly chasing it. Dataminr raised USD 100M from Fortress Investment Group in April 2025 “to accelerate its development of generative and agentic AI products,” following USD 85M (March 2025) from NightDragon and HSBC.²⁷ I flag the “\$4.1B valuation” figure that circulates with Dataminr as the 2021 Series F mark, not a current valuation;²⁴ the 2025 raises are convertible or credit, not a fresh primary equity mark.²⁷ Babel Street publicly markets “agentic AI for accelerated insights into global security,” with “multilingual data summarization, pattern identification, and social connection analysis” as its AI workflow claim.²⁸ Palantir positions its AIP — using “generative and agentic AI models, including large language models (LLMs)” inside Gotham and Foundry, deployed to government from 2023 — as the operationalization layer over intelligence data.²⁹ Palantir's relevance to *this* front, though, is as the fusion layer that *ingests* OSINT, not as a pure collector. And Fivecast, the Australian specialist, raised an AUD 30M Series A for an “AI and machine-learning-powered” platform scanning “social media and the dark web.”³⁰

The shared public claim across these vendors is that large-language-model and agentic AI compress the time from raw public-data ingestion to analyst-ready insight. The observable proxies are funding explicitly earmarked for generative or agentic AI (Dataminr's April-2025 round states this purpose verbatim), public product-page repositioning toward “agentic,” and named government reference wins. If the AI-native entrants cannot be named from public pages with a public capability claim, this trend demotes from a central convergence pillar to a watchlist item. For now, several of them *can* be named, which is what keeps it a live candidate.

Regulatory and procurement structure

How U.S. federal OSINT is bought. Government OSINT in the United States is bought predominantly through commercial-off-the-shelf software subscriptions on established federal vehicles, not through bespoke sovereign systems. That is the accessible-procurement pattern, and a sharp contrast to the classified-collection fronts. The GSA Schedule, via reseller Carahsoft, is the dominant vehicle: Babel Street's "AI-powered solutions," OSINT included, were added to "Carahsoft's GSA Schedule contract," making them available to "Federal, State and Local Government agencies."³¹ The named, dated award evidence on the public record makes the contestability concrete:

Buyer	Vendor	Value	What it bought
FBI	Babel Street	up to USD 27M (2022)	5,000 software licenses ³²
DoD (PADELS)	Dataminr	USD 24,923,076.93	enterprise OSINT alerting subscription, 36-week + 15-week option ³³

I read the Babel Street-versus-Dataminr GAO bid protest over the DoD PADELS award³³ as the cleanest public signal that this is a *recompeted, contestable* procurement lane. Vendors litigate the awards on the public record – in contrast to the incumbent-locked sovereign systems elsewhere in this report.

The In-Q-Tel signal. In-Q-Tel, the intelligence community's non-profit strategic investor, "funded primarily by the Central Intelligence Agency," is the public signal of which commercial data and AI capabilities the community is steering toward. It has invested in roughly 490 companies over 25 years, with 37 investments in 2025.³⁴ I carry it as a *directional* procurement-intent signal – where IC capital flows is where IC demand is forming – not as an OSINT-specific dollar figure. Its portfolio spans data and AI infrastructure broadly, and pinning a specific OSINT thesis on it from public sources would over-claim.

Consolidation as a market-structure force. The 2024–2025 deal flow shows OSINT and intelligence assets being absorbed into larger platforms. Mastercard acquired Recorded Future for USD 2.65B from Insight Partners (announced September 2024), framing it as "the world's largest threat intelligence company."^{26 35} Cobwebs Technologies, the Israeli WEBINT vendor, joined PenLink after being acquired for roughly USD 200M by Spire Capital, the private-equity firm that also owns PenLink – the deal that defines the current PenLink/Cobwebs entity referenced in this report.³⁶ That single-entity status, and Babel Street's current ownership, are flagged for re-confirmation when the contenders are graded.

The scraping and privacy vector – asymmetric, and the front's defining medium-term risk. OSINT's raw material is openly-available data, which puts it squarely inside the 2024–2026 tightening of data-broker and scraping law. That is a real force, but an *asymmetric* one, because national-security and law-enforcement use is frequently carved out.

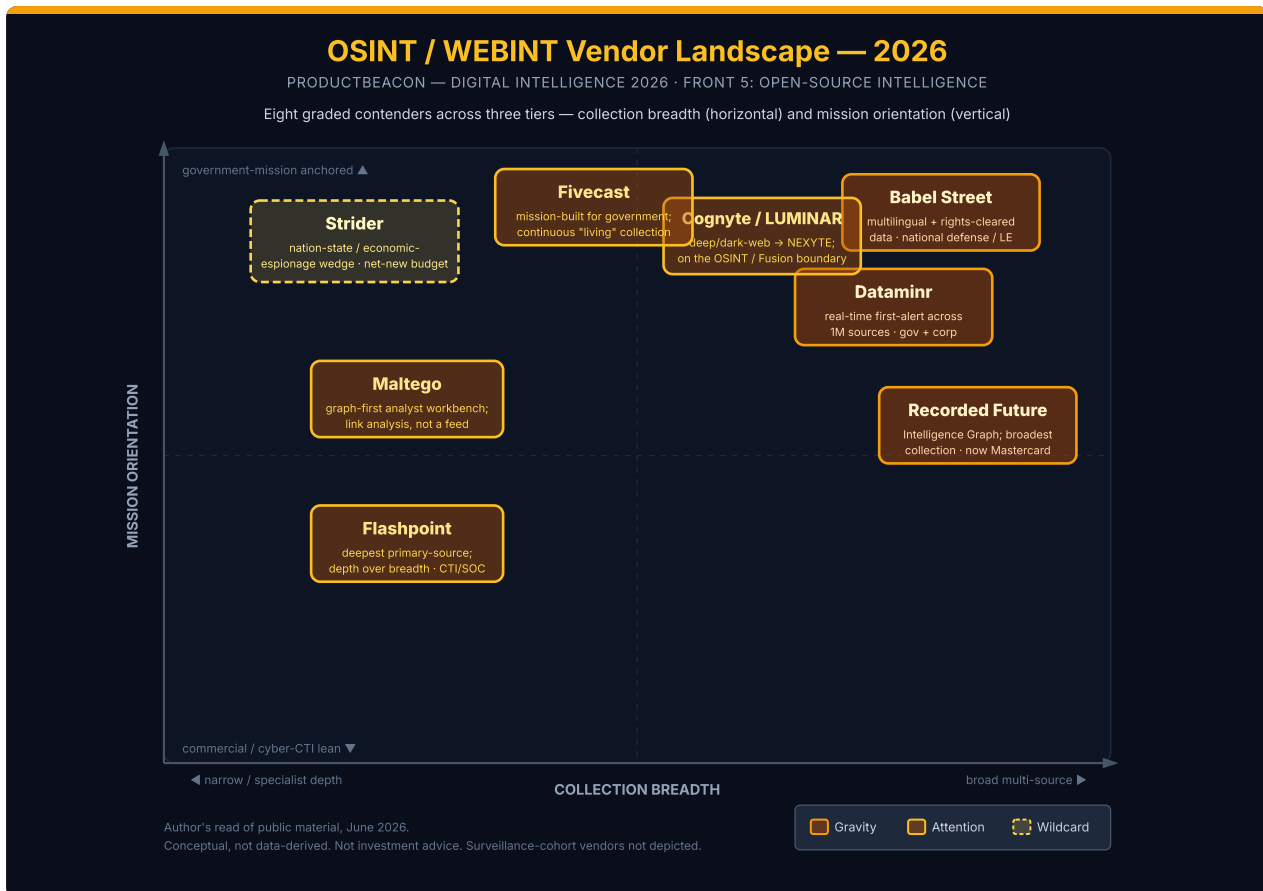
On the commercial edge, scraping of public personal data is under sustained legal pressure. Clearview AI's facial-image scraping drew more than EUR 91M in fines across 15 jurisdictions by 2025, including a EUR 20M Italian order and a EUR 30.5M Dutch order. It also drew a roughly USD 51M class-action settlement that received final approval on 2025-03-20. The regulatory backdrop is one in which EU authorities have held that "public availability is not a sufficient lawful basis under GDPR."³⁷ U.S.

enforcement tightened and then partly reversed, with a carve-out running through both moves. The FTC finalized orders in January 2025 against Mobilewalla, Gravy Analytics, and X-Mode/Outlogic barring the sale of sensitive location data — orders that *exempt* national-security and law-enforcement purposes.³⁸ Meanwhile the CFPB's broader data-broker rule, which would have classed some brokers as FCRA consumer-reporting agencies, was withdrawn on 2025-05-15.³⁹

I read the net regulatory vector as ambiguous-but-tightening on the commercial edge and carved-out on the government edge. Consumer-facing data-broker selling is constrained, while law-enforcement and national-security access is repeatedly exempted, and the most sweeping U.S. broker rule was withdrawn. If a major OSINT or WEBINT vendor loses a government contract or faces a regulator order *specifically tied* to public-data scraping during 2026–2027, the “government edge is carved out” read weakens. The carve-outs are publicly contested. Citizen Lab's analysis of PenLink's ad-based geolocation and Amnesty International's reporting on Palantir and Babel Street surveillance concerns are the named-outlet evidence of that³⁸, and I surface those only as descriptive public market-force commentary, not as a pattern claim. This legal vector is, to my read, the most likely source of a 2026–2027 discontinuity in this front.

5.3 The Contenders

Open-source intelligence is the front where the candidate list overflows the cap rather than struggling to fill it. The structural map surfaces sixteen-plus public OSINT/WEBINT vendors with quotable self-positioning, so the discipline here is *cutting*. The job is to choose the eight that define the front's center of gravity, shape its 2026 demand, and carry the architecture-disruption story — not to backfill thin rows. Eight vendors are graded across three tiers: 3 Gravity (the structural anchors a buyer cannot map the front without naming), 4 Attention (the vendors shaping demand, M&A, and the AI-native narrative), and 1 Wildcard (the funded specialist whose trajectory is the interesting bet). The remaining candidates are placed deliberately — as cross-references, as Plays, or cut — and the cut line is documented at the end of this section so the selection can be defended.



Author's read of public material, June 2026. Vendor positions are conceptual, not data-derived. Tier color-coding: Gravity (burnt orange), Attention (amber), Wildcard (pale amber). Not investment advice.

Gravity tier

Recorded Future

"Threat Intelligence cuts through the noise with a clear and comprehensive view of the threats that matter to your organization." — Recorded Future, Threat Intelligence product page, accessed 2026-06-14⁴⁰

Recorded Future is the category's structural anchor, publicly described as "the world's largest threat intelligence company, with more than 1,900 clients across 75 countries, including the governments of 45 countries and over 50% of the Fortune 100."⁴¹ Its stated USP is breadth of collection: indexing surface web, dark web, and technical feeds into a single Intelligence Graph that produces risk scores, with customers citing "the huge amount of sources from which they are gathering intelligence."⁴⁰ Target buyer is the threat-intelligence team, threat analyst, and SOC team across enterprise and government. Pricing signal: named-outlet aggregation puts entry pricing for small organizations at "\$50,000–\$100,000 annually,"⁴² a rare public anchor in a front where most pricing is dark. Architecturally — and this is positioning, not a verified internal read — it presents as a graph-native data platform with bolt-on

generative-AI assistance, marketing AI as an analyst accelerant layered on the Intelligence Graph rather than an LLM-native core. Sourcing here is rich: vendor-controlled self-positioning plus heavy named-outlet coverage.

The single most consequential ownership fact in the front sits here: **Mastercard acquired Recorded Future for \$2.65B**, announced 12 September 2024 and closed 20 December 2024. The category's largest pure-play is now a payments-giant subsidiary inside Mastercard's cyber and identity portfolio.⁴³ I read this as the central tension of the Gravity tier. The structural anchor is no longer independent, which is both a distribution windfall (Mastercard's reach) and an open question about how a government-sector franchise fares inside a commercial payments parent.

Dataminr

"AI-Powered Real-Time Event, Threat & Risk Intelligence ... Dataminr's AI platform delivers the earliest warnings on high impact events." — Dataminr homepage, accessed 2026-06-14⁴⁴

Dataminr is the speed archetype of the front. It positions as "The Leading AI Platform for Real-Time Event, Threat & Risk Intelligence,"⁴⁴ and its defining claim is *earliest signal*, first-alert latency rather than depth of after-the-fact analysis. The stated differentiation is real-time scale across "1M public data sources," built on "50+ proprietary LLMs." That stack adds multi-modal fusion, generative, and agentic AI.⁴⁴ Target buyer spans corporate security, the public sector ("100+ U.S. government agencies, 20+ international governments"), and newsrooms ("1,500+ newsrooms").⁴⁴ On architecture, Dataminr markets itself among the most AI-native vendors in the front. The multi-modal-fusion / generative / agentic stack is presented as the product's core, not a bolt-on, and in March 2026 it launched "Dataminr for Cyber Defense," a suite "built with agentic and predictive AI at its core."⁴⁵ That this is positioning rather than externally verifiable architecture is the standing caveat across the whole front. Ownership: private; the 2026 story is the cyber-defense expansion, which I read as Dataminr extending from real-time alerting toward the fusion/analytics layer — a move up the stack toward where Recorded Future and the Fusion / Decision Intelligence platforms already sit.

Babel Street

"Babel Street Data Dominance™ helps you turn chaotic and multilingual digital exhaust into verified, contextual intelligence — at scale." — Babel Street homepage, accessed 2026-06-14⁴⁶

Babel Street is the multilingual-and-licensed-data anchor of the Gravity tier. Its 2026 framing leads with "Agentic Risk Intelligence" and "Governed AI agents on rights-cleared, mission-grade data to produce decision-ready intelligence in minutes, not days," under the buyer line "Trusted by those who can't afford to be wrong."⁴⁶ The stated USP pairs multilingual breadth (a "200+ languages" lineage) with a "rights-cleared, mission-grade data" governance pitch — positioning data-licensing and provenance as the differentiator against scrape-only rivals. Target buyer is national defense, law enforcement, global enterprise, and FinTech. Architecturally it markets a 2026 repositioning toward "governed AI agents" over

a proprietary licensed-data foundation (positioning, not verified). Ownership and freshness: private; its funding lineage and ownership could not be cleanly reconciled from named-outlet reporting (aggregator figures conflict), so they are treated as undisclosed here.⁴⁷

The 2025–26 surface is an aggressive build-and-hire cycle. **John Larson (ex-Booz Allen) appointed President and Chief AI Officer in December 2025**, alongside Maura Burns (ex-CIA COO) as strategic advisor in November 2025 and a new CRO — a leadership stack I read as signalling a deeper federal-and-AI push.⁴⁸ (The earlier IP M&A that built the analytics base — Vertical Knowledge, Rosette, and the Dunami link-analysis IP — is 2020, not a recent event, and is named here only to place the lineage, not as 2026 momentum.⁴⁹)

Attention tier

Flashpoint

“The Best Data for The Best Intelligence ... Stay ahead with intelligence sourced from where threats begin, guided by experts and AI.” — Flashpoint homepage, accessed 2026-06-14⁵⁰

Flashpoint is the primary-source-depth contender — its third pillar is “Industry’s Deepest Primary Source Intelligence ... Access data from real adversary spaces that others can’t reach.”⁵⁰ Where Recorded Future and Dataminr lead on open-web breadth, Flashpoint leads on direct access to closed adversary spaces (illicit forums, marketplaces), with human-analyst enrichment as an explicit pillar (“Enriched by Expert Analyst Insight”).⁵⁰ Target buyer spans CTI/SOC, fraud, corporate and physical security, vulnerability management, national security, and insider-threat teams, with named clients including the US DoD and Microsoft.⁵⁰ On architecture it positions human-plus-AI. In 2025 it added “AI Summarization ... for Search and Investigations within Flashpoint Ignite,”⁵¹ framing AI as an analyst force-multiplier over a primary-source data lake (the Echosec acquisition supplied its social/OSINT collection layer). Ownership: private; the 2026 surface is the Ignite platform plus AI summarization and the annual Global Threat Intelligence Report as a demand-gen anchor.⁵² My read: Flashpoint’s wedge is depth-over-breadth, and the durable question is whether primary-source access stays defensible as the generalists’ AI layers get better at synthesizing the open web.

Cognyte (LUMINAR / external threat intelligence)

Disclosure: the author, Yohay Etsion, served as VP Product at Cognyte. This is independent ProductBeacon research based solely on publicly available material; it reflects the author’s personal analysis, not Cognyte’s position, and is not investment advice.

“Cognyte is a global leader in investigative analytics software that empowers a variety of government and other organizations with Actionable Intelligence for a Safer World™.” — Cognyte corporate homepage, accessed 2026-06-14⁵³

Cognyte is graded in this front strictly on its publicly-marketed external/web intelligence product, LUMINAR, plus its corporate positioning — sourced entirely to dated public pages, with no internal knowledge. LUMINAR is positioned as an “AI-powered external threat intelligence solution that empowers security and risk management leaders with comprehensive visibility into their threat landscape,” spanning “brand protection, fraud monitoring, executive protection and deep/dark web monitoring.”⁵⁴ The publicly-readable USP is the web and deep/dark-web collection layer, marketed alongside the NEXYTE decision-intelligence platform — breadth-of-source into a single investigative workspace rather than a standalone OSINT-collector pitch. (Cognyte’s public pages present LUMINAR and NEXYTE as a pairing; I do not assert a verified data pipeline between them from public material.) Target buyer, per the public pages, is “national SOCs, as well as the critical infrastructure, telecom, financial services, transportation and healthcare sectors,”⁵⁴ within a government, law enforcement, and national-security base of “hundreds of customers in approximately 100 countries.”⁵³

Architecturally, NEXYTE markets “domain-specific, pre-trained AI models,” “co-pilots,” and “agentic decision flows.”⁵⁵ That is a positioning move toward AI-native decision intelligence. Whether the underlying architecture is LLM-native or bolt-on cannot be verified from outside, so this is read as positioning only. A scope note matters here. Cognyte’s broader WEBINT family beyond LUMINAR is **not** forced into a grade here, because no clean public quotable pillar for it exists; its portfolio breadth across the five fronts is carried by the Convergence chapter rather than manufactured into a grade in this section. My read: the public LUMINAR + NEXYTE framing places Cognyte squarely on the boundary between Open-Source Intelligence and Fusion, where LUMINAR is an external-collection product marketed next to a decision-intelligence platform, which is exactly the collector-or-fusion ambiguity this front turns on.

Maltego

“OSINT & Cyber Investigations Platform for High-Stakes Cases ... From data to intelligence - in minutes.” — Maltego homepage, accessed 2026-06-14⁵⁶

Maltego is the analyst-workbench archetype — graded not as a data feed but as the link-analysis surface other data providers plug into. It positions “the all-in-one investigation platform that accelerates complex cyber investigations from hours to minutes.”⁵⁶ Its stated USP is graph-first link analysis: “the most widely used graph analysis platform for OSINT in the world,”⁵⁷ drawing “relationships between people, domains, infrastructure, social networks and leaks from open sources and commercial APIs, all on a single interactive graph.”⁵⁷ The connector/transform ecosystem is the moat — Maltego is the *de facto* standard analyst workbench that third-party data providers (including Social Links) integrate into. Target buyer, per its own page, is “Government organizations (2K+)” and “Private companies (4K+)” across law enforcement, defense and national security, CTI, banking, and insurance.⁵⁶ Architecture: graph-native, connector-driven, usage-based, adding “AI-powered sentiment analysis”⁵⁶ as a bolt-on rather than an LLM-native rebuild. Ownership: Maltego Technologies GmbH (Munich); the 2026 positioning is incremental AI features on the graph workbench. The reason it earns a grade is architectural distinctness — it is the investigator-workbench / link-analysis archetype sitting at the boundary between Open-Source Intelligence and Fusion, structurally different from the data-feed archetype of the Gravity three.

Fivecast

"Fivecast delivers an open-source intelligence platform that cuts through complex digital noise to surface the signals that matter." – Fivecast homepage, accessed 2026-06-14⁵⁸

Fivecast is the clearest *mission-built-for-government* OSINT collector in the cut. Its pillars run under the brand line "ENGINEERED FOR INTELLIGENCE"⁵⁸: "transforms digital noise into clarity, data into insight, and insight into decisive action" and "AI-powered technology that enables intelligence teams to uncover critical insights from masses of online data - before risk becomes reality." They frame a platform "born from collaboration between governments and research institutions," with "deep, targeted, and continuous data collection in near-real time."⁵⁸ That is its stated USP. It is purpose-built for the national-security, defense, and law-enforcement mission, distinct from the cyber-CTI lean of Recorded Future and Flashpoint. Target buyer, per its page, is "Government agencies (40+)," "Law enforcement (30+ police departments)," plus national security, defense intelligence, financial crime, and border security.⁵⁸ Architecturally it markets AI-powered collection-and-analysis as the core and positions on continuous "living intelligence" collection. Ownership: private, Australia-headquartered with a global footprint. The 2026 momentum is partnership-led – the Tranquility AI partnership announced in March 2026 (covered in the Plays section) – alongside a heavy government-event presence at the OSINT Tech Expo and SOF Week 2026.⁵⁹⁶⁰ My read: Fivecast is the test case for whether a government-mission specialist can reach a full collect-to-evidence workflow through partnership stacks rather than M&A.

Wildcard tier

Strider Technologies

"The Frontier of Strategic Intelligence ... One Platform, Powered by Agentic Intelligence." – Strider Technologies homepage, accessed 2026-06-14⁶¹

Strider is the Wildcard because it reframes what OSINT is *for*. The rest of the front serves cyber-threat and LEA-investigation centers; Strider instead markets a vertical the generalists don't own – *nation-state and economic-espionage risk* derived from public data. Its pillars promise to "make faster, more confident decisions with unparalleled insights into state-sponsored threats" and to "continuously discover, connect, and analyze global data to illuminate nation-state risk."⁶¹ Its stated USP is a "Zero-touch architecture requiring no internal client data" with a claimed reach across "90K+ Hard-to-access sources,"⁶¹ repositioning OSINT toward strategic counterintelligence – supply-chain, talent, IP, and PRC/Russia/Iran linkage. Target buyer, per its page, is "Fortune 100 companies and world leaders," critical infrastructure, financial services, high-tech/AI, academia, and government.⁶¹ Architecturally it markets an "agentic intelligence" platform and positions as AI-native, though, as with every contender in this front, true architecture is unverifiable from outside. Ownership and freshness: private; it **raised a \$55M Series C led by Pelion in September 2024, reaching roughly \$117M total.**⁶² Consistent with the Wildcard discipline, the read stays descriptive and hedged. The interesting bet is whether "strategic

intelligence" hardens into a category that pulls net-new budget away from the cyber-CTI incumbents, or stays a well-funded vertical — a question the wedge Play in the next section tracks against public proxies rather than asserts.

The cut line — why eight more public candidates are not graded here

The front's overflow forces a defensible cut. Each vendor below is real and publicly sourced; the cap simply requires a choice, and each is placed where it fits best — closer to a neighbouring front, duplicative of a graded archetype, or better carried as a Play.

- **Cybersixgill** — a strong dark-web CTI specialist (its public material cites collection of "7 million intelligence items from over 1,000 underground forums ... daily"⁶³). Cut because its positioning overlaps Flashpoint's primary-source-depth pillar without a distinct wedge in this front, and carried as a Flashpoint cross-reference and War Chest color.
- **ZeroFox** — external cybersecurity / digital-risk protection. Cut because it skews DRP/brand-protection (nearer a cyber-security front than government OSINT) and its 2026 story is an ownership event, not a positioning one (**taken private by Haveli for \$350M in May 2024**⁶⁴), making it a War Chests / consolidation data point.
- **PenLink (Tangles / WebLoc, ex-Cobwebs)** — a major LEA web-intelligence and location product. Cut from the graded set because its center of gravity is law-enforcement investigative tooling at the boundary between Open-Source Intelligence and the Monitoring Centers, and it is litigation-sensitive on location-data sourcing — carried as a consolidation Play and a Monitoring-Centers-adjacent cross-reference.
- **Primer** — defense/IC NLP-on-OSINT; cut because it positions as an AI analysis layer over unstructured data (adjacent to Fusion / Decision Intelligence) more than as an OSINT collector — placed as Convergence AI-native color and a Fusion / Decision Intelligence reference.
- **Social Links** — markets "industry-leading OSINT solutions" with "law enforcement agencies from 80+ countries."⁶⁵ Cut because much of its reach is *as a data provider inside Maltego* — the graded Maltego entry absorbs the archetype, and Social Links is named as ecosystem color.
- **ShadowDragon** — an LEA / financial-crime OSINT toolset; cut because it duplicates the Maltego / Social Links investigator-tooling archetype at smaller scale — named-reference only.
- **Skopenow** — an end-to-end OSINT platform with a sanctions / restricted-parties workflow lean; cut as sub-scale against the graded eight and overlapping the investigator-platform archetype — named as reference and as Play color on the compliance-OSINT trend.

A note on what is deliberately *not* graded: **Voyager Labs** is adjacent to this front but sits in the locked surveillance never-graded set and appears only as descriptive market-force commentary in the Plays section — no grade, no pattern claim, no distress label. The same discipline governs any NSO/Candiru/Intellexa/Ability-class mention: never graded here, descriptive only, and any negative anchored to a named outlet or dropped.

5.4 Their Plays

Five strategic moves are in motion across the OSINT / WEBINT front in 2026. Each is anchored to a dated public event, names its participants, and carries a falsifiable read grounded on a publicly observable proxy — an acquisition close, an earnings or funding disclosure, a public procurement record, or a named product-line launch. Two of the five are consolidation plays, one is a front-wide positioning convergence, and two are growth bets on new buying centers. The surveillance-vendor cohort appears in this section only as descriptive market-force commentary; it is never graded.

Play 1: The Category Leader Is Absorbed Into a Payments Network

- **Observation.** Mastercard agreed to acquire Recorded Future for \$2.65B, with Insight Partners as the selling owner ⁶⁷⁶⁸. The deal release described Recorded Future as a company serving “the governments of 45 countries and over 50% of the Fortune 100” ⁶⁶, and the transaction was announced 12 September 2024 and finalized 20 December 2024. This is the largest single ownership event on the front: the OSINT/threat-intelligence category’s biggest pure-play is now a subsidiary of a payments network, folded toward identity, fraud, and real-time decisioning.
- **Participants.** Mastercard (NYSE: MA), Recorded Future, Insight Partners (seller).
- **My read.** I read this as the leading edge of OSINT being absorbed into adjacent platform companies rather than persisting as a standalone software category. Threat intelligence has become strategic enough that a non-defense platform buys the category leader outright — and the buyer’s logic is data adjacency (fraud, identity, transaction risk), not the government-intelligence mission that built Recorded Future’s roster.
- **Falsifiable read.** *If H2 2026 brings a second large OSINT or cyber-threat-intelligence pure-play acquired by a non-defense platform — payments, cloud, or identity — the absorption thesis strengthens into a pattern. The read flips if instead Recorded Future’s named public-sector references visibly contract after the close, with government customers dropping from its published roster: the integration is straining the government franchise rather than extending it.*
- **Evidence.** Mastercard acquisition release, 12 Sep 2024 ⁶⁶; Mastercard close announcement, 20 Dec 2024 ⁶⁸.

Play 2: “Agentic AI” Repositioning Sweeps the Entire Front

- **Observation.** Across the graded set, vendors are simultaneously reframing from “search and alert” to “agents that act.” Dataminr launched “Dataminr for Cyber Defense,” a suite it describes as “built with agentic and predictive AI at its core,” in March 2026 ⁶⁹. Babel Street’s 2026 homepage leads with “Agentic Risk Intelligence” and “Governed AI agents on rights-cleared, mission-grade data” ⁷⁰. Strider markets “One Platform, Powered by Agentic Intelligence” ⁷¹. Cognyte’s NEXYTE platform page cites “agentic decision flows” ⁷². Maltego and Flashpoint, by contrast, add AI as bolt-on summarization rather than rearchitecting around it ⁷³⁷⁴.

- **Participants.** Dataminr, Babel Street, Strider, Cognyte leading the reframe; Maltego and Flashpoint adding AI as an analyst force-multiplier.
- **My read.** I read this as a positioning convergence, not yet a verified capability gap. Every contender is racing to attach the “agentic” label to its homepage. But whether the underlying architecture is genuinely LLM-native or a generative-AI layer over an existing graph or data foundation cannot be verified from outside. The claims are marketing surface, and treating them as architecture would be an error. This is the falsifiable form of the report’s cross-front “AI-native disruption” pillar: name the public claimants, frame each as “positions itself as,” and let a public proof point decide it.
- **Falsifiable read.** *The test through H2 2026 is whether any of these vendors publishes a named-reference customer attributing a decision or operational outcome to autonomous agentic action – as distinct from analyst-assisted workflow. If that proof point lands for one vendor and not the others, the AI-native claims begin to separate into a real differentiator. If “agentic” remains category-wide marketing language with no named-outcome reference behind it, it is a label the whole front shares, not a moat any single vendor holds – and the pillar demotes to a watchlist item.*
- **Evidence.** Dataminr “Cyber Defense” launch, Mar 2026 ⁶⁹; Babel Street homepage ⁷⁰; Strider homepage ⁷¹; Cognyte NEXYTE page ⁷².

Play 3: Private Equity Rolls Up the LEA Web-Intelligence Suite

- **Observation.** Private equity is assembling law-enforcement-facing investigative-OSINT suites out of fragmented point products. Cobwebs Technologies was acquired for roughly \$200M in 2023 and folded into PenLink, both held under Spire Capital ⁷⁵⁷⁶. PenLink’s Tangles product was subsequently signed by the Texas Department of Public Safety on a five-year contract worth approximately \$5.3M in June 2025 ⁷⁷. In parallel, ZeroFox was taken private by Haveli Investments at an enterprise value near \$350M, a deal that closed 13 May 2024 ⁷⁸.
- **Participants.** Spire Capital, Haveli Investments, the rolled-up vendors (PenLink/Cobwebs, ZeroFox), and US state and federal law-enforcement buyers.
- **My read.** I read this as PE betting on two things. First, that fragmented LEA-OSINT tooling consolidates into platform suites, combining web-intelligence collection with location and forensic analysis under one owner. Second, that public procurement keeps funding the category even as privacy scrutiny intensifies around location-data sourcing. The Texas DPS contract is the public proof that the demand curve is still live despite that scrutiny.
- **Falsifiable read.** *If H2 2026 brings another PE-backed acquisition combining a web-intelligence collector with a location or forensics product, the roll-up thesis holds. The thesis faces a public-policy headwind if instead new state-level procurement restrictions on location-data tools appear in the public record, following the documented Texas/PenLink scrutiny – a headwind the roll-up’s economics did not price in.*
- **Evidence.** PenLink/Cobwebs acquisition, 2023 ⁷⁵⁷⁶; Texas DPS Tangles contract, Jun 2025 ⁷⁷; Haveli/ZeroFox close, May 2024 ⁷⁸.

Play 4: Government-Mission Pure-Plays Grow Through Partnership Stacks

- **Observation.** The government-mission OSINT specialists are reaching a fuller collect-to-evidence workflow through partnership rather than acquisition. Tranquility AI and Fivecast announced a partnership “to Accelerate Open-Source Intelligence Analysis for Government and Law Enforcement” in March 2026, combining Fivecast’s large-scale collection with Tranquility’s evidence-analysis platforms⁷⁹. Fivecast’s 2026 posture is heavily event-led, with a documented presence at SOF Week 2026 and the OSINT Tech Expo⁸⁰.
- **Participants.** Fivecast, Tranquility AI, and government / law-enforcement buyers.
- **My read.** I read this as the specialists deliberately choosing partnership over M&A to assemble the full workflow. It is a lighter-weight path to a collect-to-evidence stack than the capital-intensive roll-ups of Play 3, and one that keeps the specialist independent rather than absorbed. It is the mirror image of the consolidation trade: build the workflow by alliance, not by balance sheet.
- **Falsifiable read.** *If H2 2026 brings a second comparable collection-plus-analysis partnership, or a named government reference win attributed to the Fivecast–Tranquility stack, the partnership-stack model is working as an independent growth path. If instead these stacks get acquired into a generalist’s portfolio, it confirms that the consolidation pull of Plays 1 and 3 is stronger than the case for independent specialist growth.*
- **Evidence.** Tranquility AI–Fivecast partnership, BusinessWire, 17 Mar 2026⁷⁹; Fivecast SOF Week / OSINT Tech Expo presence, 2026⁸⁰.

Play 5: A Nation-State / Strategic-Intelligence Wedge Draws Net-New Budget

- **Observation.** A vertical the generalists do not own — corporate strategic and supply-chain counterintelligence against nation-state risk — is attracting its own capital. Strider Technologies raised a \$55M Series C led by Pelion Venture Partners in September 2024, its largest round to date and roughly \$117M in total funding⁸¹. Its positioning is “unparalleled insights into state-sponsored threats” and a “Zero-touch architecture requiring no internal client data”⁷¹. Babel Street, meanwhile, has built out a federal-and-threat leadership stack through 2025, including appointing John Larson (ex-Booz Allen) as President and Chief AI Officer in December 2025⁸².
- **Participants.** Strider, Babel Street, and Fortune-100 / critical-infrastructure buyers.
- **My read.** I read this as a genuinely new buying center — corporate strategic, supply-chain, and IP-protection counterintelligence — splitting off from the established cyber-CTI and LEA-investigation centers, rather than a repackaging of generic threat intelligence. The funded specialist (Strider) and the incumbent building toward the same wedge (Babel Street) are both betting that “strategic intelligence” becomes a line item of its own.
- **Falsifiable read.** *If through H2 2026 a generalist — Recorded Future under Mastercard, or Dataminr — publicly launches a named “nation-state” or “supply-chain risk” product line, it validates the wedge as a category the incumbents must answer. If instead Strider’s next disclosed funding round stalls, or it pivots its public messaging back toward generic threat intelligence, the wedge was narrower than the raise implied.*

- **Evidence.** Strider Series C, Sep 2024⁸¹; Strider homepage positioning⁷¹; Babel Street leadership build, Dec 2025⁸².

Market-force commentary: the surveillance-vendor shadow (not graded)

Voyager Labs sits adjacent to this front as a social-media-analysis and web-intelligence vendor that has been the subject of public litigation regarding social-media data collection. It is named here as descriptive market-force context only – no grade, no pattern claim, and no distress, decline, or sanctions characterization. Any such statement would require a named-outlet anchor that is out of scope for a non-graded vendor. Its relevance to the OSINT/WEBINT front is as a marker of the litigation-and-platform-policy risk surface that shadows the social-media-intelligence sub-segment as a whole – the same headwind that Play 3's public-policy conditional turns on. The same discipline applies to any mention of the remote-mobile-exploitation cohort: never graded, descriptive only, and named-outlet-attributed-or-dropped on any negative.

5.5 War Chests & Casualties

A snapshot of the capital behind the OSINT / WEBINT front – recent rounds, public valuations, the strategic investors and owners, and any distress signal that meets the evidentiary bar. Every figure traces to a named outlet, a filing, or the vendor's own dated press release. Where no public figure exists, the table records "not disclosed" rather than reaching for an aggregator estimate. The Distress Signal column is populated only where a same-paragraph public footnote anchors a specific event; absent that, it reads "none observed." Litigation-sensitive vendors are listed descriptively and never graded.

Vendor	Most Recent Round / Public Status	Valuation (if public)	Strategic Investor or Owner	Distress Signal
Recorded Future (US – threat intelligence / OSINT at scale)	Acquired by Mastercard; closed 2024-12-20 (announced 2024-09-12) ⁸³⁸⁴	\$2.65B acquisition price ⁸³	Sold by Insight Partners (owner since 2019) to Mastercard (NYSE: MA) ⁸³	None observed – strategic exit at scale, not distress
Dataminr (US – real-time public-signal / event intelligence)	\$100M convertible financing led by Fortress Investment Group, closed 2025-04-24 ⁸⁵	\$4.1B (last <i>priced</i> round, Series F, Mar 2021; the 2025 round was convertible, not a fresh primary mark) ⁸⁶	Fortress Investment Group, NightDragon; priors include Valor, Fidelity ⁸⁵	2023 staff reduction (~20%) reported by named outlet – treated descriptively, not as a casualty label ⁸⁷
ZeroFox (US – external cybersecurity / digital-risk OSINT)	Take-private by Haveli Investments; closed 2024-05-13 (~\$350M EV; \$1.14/share) ⁸⁸	~\$350M enterprise value; \$1.14/share, a 45% premium to 90-day VWAP ⁸⁸	Haveli Investments (tech-focused PE) ⁸⁸	Take-private priced well below SPAC-era levels – treated descriptively
Cybersixgill (IL – dark-web cyber threat intelligence)	Acquired by Bitsight; announced 2024-11-14, closed 2024-12-11 (~\$115M) ⁸⁹⁹⁰⁹⁶	~\$115M acquisition price (named outlet) ⁸⁹	Acquired by Bitsight ⁸⁹	None observed – strategic acquisition
Strider Technologies (US – strategic / nation-state intelligence)	\$55M Series C led by Pelion Venture Partners, 2024-09-12 ⁹¹	Not disclosed (~\$117M total funding, directional)	Pelion Venture Partners (lead); AXA Venture Partners, Valor Equity, DataTribe ⁹¹	None observed
Fivecast (AU – OSINT for defense / Five Eyes)	US\$20M (AU\$30M) Series A led by Ten Eleven Ventures, 2023-04 ⁹²	Not disclosed	Ten Eleven Ventures (lead); Main Sequence (CSIRO fund), SA Venture Capital Fund ⁹²	None observed
PenLink / Cobwebs (US/IL – digital investigation + WEBINT/OSINT)	PenLink acquired Cobwebs, 2023-07-11 (~\$200M, via PE owner Spire Capital) ⁹³⁹⁴	~\$200M (named-outlet valuation of the Cobwebs deal) ⁹⁴	Spire Capital (PE owner of PenLink) ⁹³	None observed

The capital story across 2024–2026 is consolidation, not greenfield. Three of the largest pure-play names exited to acquirers inside an eighteen-month window: Recorded Future to Mastercard at \$2.65B (closed December 2024)⁸⁴, Cybersixgill to Bitsight at roughly \$115M⁸⁹, and ZeroFox to PE at a ~\$350M take-private⁸⁸. Dataminr extended the roll-up by acquiring ThreatConnect for about \$290M – announced October 2025, closed 2025-11-25⁹⁵. Capital concentrates around two poles: strategic and government-aligned money on one side (the Five-Eyes-facing Fivecast and Strider raises⁹¹⁹²) and private-equity control on the other (Insight, Haveli, Spire, and the Fortress-backed Dataminr convertible⁸⁵). The standalone-public path has effectively closed for this cohort – ZeroFox de-listed, Recorded Future absorbed into a payments network – and no fresh primary mega-round on a pure-play OSINT collector surfaced in named-outlet reporting in the window. One name resists clean resolution. Babel Street’s ownership and funding could not be reconciled from named-outlet sources (aggregators conflict on whether it is bootstrapped, PE-backed, or lightly funded), so it is recorded as privately held and undisclosed rather than cited from an aggregator.

Not investment advice. See Disclosures.

5.6 Winning & Losing

Three patterns govern who is gaining ground and who is ceding it on the OSINT/WEBINT front in 2026. Each is anchored to a specific public event, framed explicitly as opinion, and stated as a falsifiable prediction the next two quarters will confirm or refute. Read them in sequence. The first is the structural fact of the front: the independent brand is being absorbed. The second is the positioning move every survivor is making in response: the agentic pivot. The third is the demand-side dynamic that determines who keeps pricing power once the smoke clears – an accessible, contestable procurement lane with a free floor pressing up from below.

Pattern Claim 1 – The Strategic-Acquirer Absorption Thesis

Observation. In an eighteen-month window the OSINT/WEBINT front lost three of its most prominent independent brands to acquirers, and a fourth agreed to roll up a fifth. Mastercard bought Recorded Future – described in the deal release as “the world’s largest threat intelligence company, with more than 1,900 clients across 75 countries, including the governments of 45 countries”⁹⁷ – for \$2.65B, announced 12 Sep 2024 and finalized 20 Dec 2024⁹⁸. Bitsight agreed to acquire dark-web specialist Cybersixgill for ~\$115M (announced 14 Nov 2024)⁹⁹. Haveli Investments took ZeroFox private for ~\$350M enterprise value at \$1.14/share, closed 13 May 2024¹⁰⁰. PenLink, owned by PE firm Spire Capital, had earlier absorbed Israeli WEBINT vendor Cobwebs Technologies (~\$200M, July 2023)¹⁰¹. And Dataminr – itself last priced at \$4.1B in 2021 and recapitalized in 2025 via a \$100M Fortress convertible rather than a fresh equity mark¹⁰² – announced intent to acquire ThreatConnect for \$290M on 21 Oct 2025¹⁰³.

My read. I read this as the closing of the independent-OSINT-brand path. The category has become strategic enough that the buyers are no longer other intelligence specialists – they are payments networks (Mastercard), security-ratings platforms (Bitsight), and PE control vehicles (Haveli, Spire) folding collection assets into larger portfolios. The standalone-public route has effectively shut: ZeroFox de-listed, Recorded Future was absorbed into a payments giant, and no fresh standalone primary mega-round on a pure-play collector surfaced in named-outlet reporting across the window. The surviving independents (Babel Street, Flashpoint, Fivecast, Strider) are now either acquisition candidates or vertical specialists narrow enough to be uninteresting to a generalist acquirer – which is its own kind of moat.

Conditional prediction. *The absorption thesis hardens into the defining structure of the front under one of two triggers: H2 2026 brings a second large OSINT/CTI pure-play acquired by a non-defense platform company (payments, cloud, identity, or ratings), or a further roll-up is announced following the now-closed Dataminr/ThreatConnect deal. Remaining independents should then increasingly be read as acquisition candidates rather than durable standalones. The pull is weaker than the deal flow implied – and independent growth is still financeable – under two inverse signals. Either a pure-play collector raises a fresh, named-lead primary equity mega-round at an up valuation, or Recorded Future’s government-sector roster visibly contracts post-close, with a loss of named public-sector references signaling integration strain.*

Sources. ^{97 98 99 100 101 102 103}

Pattern Claim 2 – The Agentic Repositioning

Observation. Across 2025–2026 the front’s contenders converged on near-identical “agentic AI” homepage language. Dataminr launched “Dataminr for Cyber Defense,” a suite “built with agentic and predictive AI at its core” (Mar 2026)¹⁰⁴, and took a \$100M Fortress financing explicitly “to accelerate gen AI and agentic AI product innovation” (Apr 2025)¹⁰². Babel Street’s 2026 homepage leads with “Agentic Risk Intelligence” and “Governed AI agents on rights-cleared, mission-grade data to produce decision-ready intelligence in minutes, not days”¹⁰⁵. Strider markets “One

Platform, Powered by Agentic Intelligence”¹⁰⁶. Cognyte’s NEXYTE platform markets “co-pilots” and “agentic decision flows”¹⁰⁷. Maltego and Flashpoint, by contrast, add AI as bolt-on summarization on an existing engine¹⁰⁸¹⁰⁹.

My read. I read this strictly as a positioning convergence, not a verified capability gap — a distinction this report’s grounding discipline and its security-architecture caution both require, because true internal architecture cannot be verified from outside. What is observably real is the funding earmarked for it (Dataminr’s April-2025 round states the purpose verbatim¹⁰²) and the simultaneity of the pivot. When every contender’s hero copy carries “agentic” in the same quarter, the word has stopped differentiating and started signaling table-stakes. The genuine question is not who markets agentic AI — they all do — but who can produce a customer willing to attribute an outcome to it.

Conditional prediction. *Suppose by Q4 2026 one of these vendors publishes a named-reference customer attributing a specific decision or outcome to autonomous agentic action — as distinct from analyst-assisted search — and the others cannot. In that case the agentic claims begin to separate into a real differentiator, and that vendor earns a durable wedge. If “agentic” instead remains uniform marketing language across all of them with no named-outcome reference win through 2026 — no independent time-to-insight benchmark, no government reference framed around autonomous action — then it is a category-wide label rather than a moat. It then demotes from a central convergence pillar to a watchlist item.*

Sources.^{102 104 105 106 107 108 109}

Pattern Claim 3 — The Contestable-Lane-and-Free-Floor Squeeze

Observation. Unlike the classified-collection fronts, U.S. government OSINT is bought predominantly through commercial-off-the-shelf subscriptions on established federal vehicles. Babel Street’s AI-powered solutions were added to “Carahsoft’s GSA Schedule contract,” making them available to “Federal, State and Local Government agencies”¹¹⁰. Those awards are openly recompeted and litigated: Babel Street and Dataminr fought a GAO bid protest over the DoD PADELS publicly-available-information alerting award (valued at \$24,923,076.93)¹¹¹, while the FBI bought 5,000 Babel Street licenses for “up to \$27M” (2022)¹¹². Underneath that accessible lane sits a compressing free floor — Maltego community editions, open-source OSINT toolkits, and general-purpose LLMs now performing ad-hoc collection¹¹³ — alongside the government-share data showing government intelligence agencies as the single largest end-user segment at “38.40%” of 2025 OSINT revenue per one named publisher¹¹⁴.

My read. I read these two facts as a vise on the middle of the market. Because the procurement lane is genuinely accessible — GSA/Carahsoft subscriptions, recompeted enterprise licenses, publicly-litigated protests — a software/data specialist can enter this front without owning sovereign infrastructure. That is exactly why the front overflows with contenders and why it consolidates so fast. But the same accessibility means the low end is being eaten from below by free tooling and commodity LLMs. The vendors who keep pricing power are the ones who climb up-stack to where the free floor cannot follow: multilingual exploitation at investigative grade, dark/deep-web depth with maintained access, defensible provenance, and accredited

government deployment. The bifurcation is between vendors anchored to a government mission (Fivecast, Strider, the gov-share leaders) and vendors competing on commodity open-web collection – and the second group is structurally squeezed.

Conditional prediction. *If H2 2026 public procurement records show continued recompleted, contested OSINT awards on GSA/Carahsoft-class vehicles (new named awards or bid protests), the accessible-lane structure holds and the government-anchored specialists keep their pricing premium. The “government edge is carved out” assumption weakens instead if a major OSINT/WEBINT vendor loses a government contract or draws a regulator order specifically tied to public-data scraping during 2026 – the scenario the front’s contested scraping-law backdrop makes plausible. The squeeze then migrates upward from the commodity tier into the mission tier.*

Sources. ^{110 111 112 113 114}

Winners, Watch, Losers

Winners.

- **Recorded Future.** Sold at the top of the cycle. The \$2.65B exit to Mastercard from PE owner Insight Partners ⁹⁸ is the largest disclosed transaction in the front. It is the cleanest “winning” outcome available to a pure-play: a strategic acquirer paid a payments-network premium for the category’s most-cited brand. The Winners label is opinion-labeled and scoped to the transaction, not to post-close execution, which the conditional in Pattern Claim 1 flags as the open risk.
- **Dataminr.** The lone independent still acting as a consolidator rather than a target: a \$100M Fortress financing (Apr 2025) ¹⁰² funding the agentic build, plus its \$290M ThreatConnect acquisition (announced Oct 2025, closed 2025-11-25) ¹⁰³ extending it from real-time alerting toward the fusion/analytics layer. I read Dataminr as winning the “independent that buys rather than gets bought” position in 2026. The caveat is that its last priced mark is the 2021 \$4.1B Series F and the 2025 raise was a convertible, not a fresh equity up-round ¹⁰².
- **Strider Technologies.** Winning the net-new vertical, not the incumbent fight. A \$55M Series C led by Pelion (Sep 2024, ~\$117M total) ¹¹⁵ funds a nation-state / economic-espionage wedge – “The Frontier of Strategic Intelligence” ¹⁰⁶ – that the cyber-CTI generalists do not own. It is winning a budget line, not a market-share war, which is the defensible thing to win when the generalists are consolidating.

Watch.

- **Babel Street.** The most active independent build-and-hire of 2026 – “Agentic Risk Intelligence” repositioning ¹⁰⁵, a federal-and-AI leadership stack (John Larson, ex-Booz Allen, as President and Chief AI Officer, Dec 2025) ¹¹⁶, and a Carahsoft/GSA federal channel ¹¹⁰. But its ownership and funding could not be cleanly resolved from named-outlet reporting; it is recorded as privately held, ownership undisclosed ¹¹⁷. Watch signal: a fresh named-lead primary round (which would test Pattern Claim 1’s “independent growth is still financeable” branch) or an acquisition (which would confirm the absorption branch).

- **Fivecast.** The clearest government-mission OSINT pure-play in the cut – “Government agencies (40+),” “Law enforcement (30+ police departments)”¹¹⁸ – pursuing a partnership stack rather than M&A to reach a full collect-to-evidence workflow. That is the Tranquility AI collection-plus-evidence partnership, Mar 2026¹¹⁹, on a US\$20M Series A base (2023)¹²⁰. Watch signal: a named government reference win from the partnership, or the partnership stack itself getting acquired into a generalist’s portfolio.

Losers.

No graded contender in this front earns a Losers label in this section. A vendor reaches this line only when a cited public event anchors a vendor-specific decline, per the casualty-evidence discipline. The qualifying events are a layoff specific to the OSINT business, a missed quarter, a down-round, a named executive departure framed as distress, or a customer-churn disclosure. The public events on this front are consolidation and strategic exit, not failure. ZeroFox’s \$1.14/share take-private¹⁰⁰ sits well below its SPAC-era levels but is a PE de-listing, not a documented operational collapse; Dataminr’s reported 2023 staff reduction¹²¹ and Primer’s pre-turnaround leadership change¹²² are descriptive context, not casualty labels. Voyager Labs and the NSO/Candiru/Intellexa/Ability cohort are litigation-sensitive and never graded; they appear only as descriptive market-force commentary elsewhere in the chapter, with no decline label asserted here. Quarterly refreshes will populate this line if an OSINT-specific distress signal emerges on the public record.

5.7 The Campaign Ahead

Five watchlist items for H2 2026. Each names a public, observable threshold that would trigger re-assessment of a claim above.

1. **A second non-defense-platform acquisition of an OSINT pure-play.** Signal to monitor: M&A announcements naming a payments, cloud, identity, or security-ratings acquirer of a standalone OSINT/CTI collector. Threshold for re-assessment: one such deal announced in H2 2026, or – with the Dataminr/ThreatConnect acquisition already closed (2025-11-25)¹⁰³ – a *further* roll-up, or a Dataminr IPO pricing → Pattern Claim 1’s absorption thesis hardens into the front’s defining structure. Inverse threshold: a fresh named-lead primary equity mega-round at an up valuation on a pure-play collector → independent growth is still financeable. Primary source: named-outlet M&A coverage (Reuters, Bloomberg, Calcalist), vendor press releases.
2. **A named-outcome agentic reference win.** Signal: public reference customers attributing a specific decision or outcome to autonomous agentic action, as distinct from analyst-assisted search, from any of Dataminr, Babel Street, Strider, or Cognyte. Threshold: one vendor publishes such a named reference (or an independent time-to-insight benchmark) and the others do not → the agentic claims begin separating into a real differentiator per Pattern Claim 2’s first branch. Inverse: “agentic” stays uniform marketing language across all of them through Q4 2026 with no named-outcome win → demote the AI-native convergence pillar to a watchlist label. Primary source: vendor press releases (Dataminr, Babel Street, Strider, Cognyte newsrooms), government reference-win coverage.

3. **A scraping-law action against a government-facing OSINT vendor.** Signal: a regulator order or lost government contract specifically tied to public-data scraping affecting a named OSINT/WEBINT vendor. The backdrop is contested – GDPR’s “public availability is not a sufficient lawful basis” line and the FTC’s national-security-carved-out location-broker orders¹²³. Threshold: one such named action in 2026 → the “government edge is carved out” read in Pattern Claim 3 weakens and the squeeze migrates from the commodity tier into the mission tier. Inverse: scraping-law enforcement stays confined to consumer-facing brokers (e.g., the Clearview-class fines¹²³) → the carve-out holds. Primary source: regulator press (FTC, EU DPAs), named-outlet legal coverage, Citizen Lab / Amnesty public analysis.
4. **Recorded Future’s government franchise post-close.** Signal: Recorded Future’s named public-sector reference roster and any government-contract activity following the Mastercard close (20 Dec 2024)⁹⁸. Threshold: visible contraction of named public-sector references, or a public-sector contract loss attributable to the acquisition → integration is straining the government franchise (Pattern Claim 1’s inverse branch). Conversely, retained or expanded named government references → the strategic acquirer preserved the franchise. Primary source: Recorded Future / Mastercard newsroom, federal procurement records (USAspending), named-outlet coverage.
5. **A generalist answering the nation-state / supply-chain wedge.** Signal: whether a generalist (Recorded Future/Mastercard, Dataminr) publicly launches a named “nation-state risk” or “supply-chain / vendor risk” product line answering Strider’s strategic-intelligence wedge¹⁰⁶. A related signal is whether Babel Street’s standing-up of a dedicated threat-and-vendor-risk function¹¹⁶ expands into a named product. Threshold: a generalist ships a named competing line in H2 2026 → the vertical wedge is validated as a category the incumbents must answer (a winning signal for Strider’s position). Inverse: Strider’s next disclosed round stalls or its messaging reverts to generic threat intel → the wedge was narrower than the raise implied. Primary source: vendor product-launch pages and press releases, funding-round coverage.

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